

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

الحمد لله والصلاة والسلام على رسول الله وعلى آله وصحبه أجمعين



Tadwīn al-Sunnah Lesson 3 Overview

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Introduction: The Question of Tadwīn

One of the most important discussions in *‘Ulūm al-Ḥadīth* is the question of **Tadwīn al-Ḥadīth** (تدوين الحديث): *Was the Sunnah written down during the lifetime of the Messenger of Allāh ﷺ, and if so, in what sense?*

This lesson examines **early evidences for writing**, analyzes **narrations that appear to prohibit writing**, and clarifies **terminological confusion** between *writing, compiling, and organizing* knowledge. A major reference throughout this discussion is **Imām al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī** (الإمام الخطيب البغدادي) and his work *Taqyīd al-‘Ilm* (تقييد العلم).

The key objective is not to argue that the Sunnah was compiled in encyclopedic form during the Prophet’s ﷺ lifetime, but rather to establish **whether writing occurred, whether it was permissible, and why large-scale compilation occurred later**.

Early Evidence for Writing in the Time of the Prophet ﷺ

The Ḥadīth of Abū Hurayrah and ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr

Among the strongest evidences cited by al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī is the statement of **Abū Hurayrah** رضي الله عنه, who said:

ما من أصحاب النبي ﷺ أحد أكثر حديثاً مني إلا ما كان من عبد الله بن عمرو، فإنه كان يكتب وأنا لا أكتب

“There was no one among the Companions of the Prophet ﷺ who narrated more ḥadīth than me, except ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr, for he used to write while I did not write.”

This narration is highly significant. It **explicitly confirms writing during the Prophet’s ﷺ lifetime**, while simultaneously indicating that **writing was not widespread among all Companions**. The contrast between Abū Hurayrah’s reliance on memorization and ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr’s reliance on writing shows that **both methods coexisted**.

The Incident of Abū Shāh at the Conquest of Makkah

Another frequently cited narration is the ḥadīth concerning the **khuṭbah of the Prophet ﷺ at the conquest of Makkah**, in which a man named **Abū Shāh** requested that the sermon be written down. The Prophet ﷺ responded:

اكتبوا لأبي شاه

“Write it for Abū Shāh.”

While this narration **clearly establishes permissibility of writing**, the lesson correctly emphasizes that it **cannot be used to prove a general policy of compilation**. The instruction was **context-specific**, directed to a particular individual in a particular circumstance. From an *uṣūlī* perspective, this is not sufficient to establish unrestricted general permissibility on its own.

However, it **does demonstrate an exception** to any absolute claim that writing was categorically prohibited, thereby weakening claims of universal prohibition.

The Ḥadīth of the Prophet's ﷺ Final Illness

Another narration discussed is the famous report in which the Prophet ﷺ, during his **marḍ al-mawt**, said:

انتوني بكتاب أكتب لكم كتاباً لن تضلوا بعده

“Bring me something to write with, so that I may write for you a document after which you will never go astray.”

This incident does show the Prophet ﷺ **commanding writing**, but it cannot be used as proof for general Tadwīn. First, the context is **exceptional**, involving a potential **waṣiyyah related to leadership (khilāfah)**. Second, the Prophet ﷺ ultimately did not write anything due to disagreement among those present.

Moreover, this represents **imlā’ (dictation by the Prophet ﷺ)** rather than independent compilation by the Companions. Thus, while relevant, it serves as **supporting evidence**, not a foundational proof.

The Strongest Evidence: Writing Everything from the Prophet ﷺ

The most decisive evidence in the lesson is the narration of ‘**Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ** رضي الله عنه, who said that he used to write **everything** he heard from the Messenger ﷺ. When some Quraysh objected, claiming that the Prophet ﷺ might speak in anger or distress, he consulted the Prophet ﷺ directly. The Prophet ﷺ replied:

اكتب، فوالذي نفسي بيده ما خرج منه إلا الحق

“Write, for by the One in whose Hand is my soul, nothing comes from it except the truth.”

This narration is **explicit, general, and unambiguous**. It establishes not only permissibility, but **affirmative command** to write the Sunnah. Unlike previous narrations, it does not depend on special circumstances and directly addresses the concern that writing might preserve non-legislative speech.

For this reason, the lesson correctly identifies this as **one of the strongest proofs** that writing the Sunnah occurred during the Prophet’s ﷺ lifetime.

Reconciling Writing with Reports of Prohibition (Nahy)

The Ḥadīth of Abū Sa‘īd al-Khudrī

The primary narration cited to argue prohibition is the report attributed to **Abū Sa‘īd al-Khudrī** رضي الله عنه, in which the Prophet ﷺ is reported to have said:

لا تكتبوا عني غير القرآن

“Do not write anything from me other than the Qur’ān.”

The lesson carefully explains that this narration is **problematic**. First, there is scholarly disagreement over whether it is **marfū‘** (attributed to the Prophet ﷺ) or **mawqūf** (a statement of Abū Sa‘īd himself). Second, Abū Sa‘īd himself is reported elsewhere to have said that they used to write the **Qur’ān and the tashahhud**, which already contradicts a literal reading of total prohibition.

From an *uṣūl al-fiqh* perspective, **a mawqūf statement does not establish binding legislation**, especially when other Companions clearly acted otherwise. Therefore, this narration cannot override the numerous reports permitting writing.

Possible Interpretations of the Prohibition

The lesson outlines several reconciliatory explanations:

1. **Temporary prohibition (naskh)**: Writing may have been discouraged initially to protect the Qur'ān, then later permitted.
2. **Contextual restriction**: The prohibition applied only to writing Qur'ān and Sunnah together in the same medium.
3. **Weakness or اضطراب (idṭirāb)**: Variations in wording and attribution weaken the narration's authority.

Any of these explanations suffices to reconcile the narrations without denying early writing.

Why Tadwīn Increased After the Companions

Expansion of Riwayāt and Chains

Imām al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī explains that **writing increased significantly during the era of the Tābi'ūn** due to the massive expansion of **isnāds**. While a single **matn** might remain unchanged, the number of **ṭuruq** multiplied. In ḥadīth methodology, each chain is counted as a separate narration.

Thus, what was once simple became complex, necessitating writing for accuracy and verification.

Emergence of ‘Ilm al-Rijāl

Another reason for increased writing was the development of **‘Ilm al-Rijāl** (علم الرجال). The Companions knew one another personally, but the Tābi‘ūn faced new generations, sects, and fitan. This required careful documentation of names, kunyahs, lineages, and reliability.

Terminological Precision: Tadwīn, Taqyīd, and Taṣnīf

A crucial clarification in the lesson is the distinction between three terms:

Taqyīd al-‘Ilm (تقييد العلم) refers to *writing knowledge down*, such as personal notes.

Tadwīn (تدوين) refers to *gathering scattered writings into a single comprehensive corpus*.

Taṣnīf (تصنيف) refers to *organizing that corpus into chapters and structured books*.

When early scholars said “*awwal man dawwana al-‘ilm*”, they meant **systematic compilation**, not the first act of writing.

Final Conclusions of the Lesson

The lesson concludes with several key findings:

1. **Writing of the Sunnah undeniably occurred during the Prophet’s** ﷺ **lifetime.**
2. **No sound, unproblematic narration establishes a permanent prohibition of writing.**
3. **Early reluctance was motivated by pedagogical and Qur’ānic priorities, not rejection of the Sunnah.**



4. **Large-scale Tadwīn and Taṣnīf emerged later due to practical necessity, not religious innovation.**

Thus, the historical development of ḥadīth preservation reflects **wisdom, gradualism, and methodological rigor**, not negligence or delay.